

Chapter 7 - Solitude

Actually, there was still some time before Yan Lin's flight, but she still didn't stay home any longer.

Just like that, Yan Lin and Feng Yue barely exchanged ten sentences before the busy CEO left again with her secretary.

After getting in the car, Yan Lin stopped the driver from heading directly to the airport and instead directed him to go straight to the hospital.

She had actually seen the bag of medicine that Feng Yue was carrying when she returned home.

Mo Yixu sat in the passenger seat and, after thinking for a moment, briefly reported on what Yan Lin had previously assigned him to handle.

"CEO Yan, the kidnapping case you asked me to deal with has been resolved," Mo Yixu said, glancing at the woman in the rearview mirror.

He didn't understand why Yan Lin would be so concerned about a kidnapping case. When he went to handle it, he had specifically checked—none of the kidnapped people were related to Yan Lin or even the Yan family.

Hearing him mention this, Yan Lin remembered there was still this matter.

She nodded slightly: "Arrange some bodyguards for Shuangshuang secretly. If my aunt asks, just say I arranged it."

"Yes."

Yan Lin still remembered that in her previous life, it was because of this kidnapping case that not only her cousin Dai Shuangshuang suffered severe trauma, but even her aunt's whole family was devastated by this incident.

She and Dai Shuangshuang had grown up together, and she truly treated this child as a younger sister.

So she didn't want the events of her previous life to repeat themselves.

However, she was also somewhat puzzled.

Clearly, in her previous life, the one who was kidnapped was Dai Shuangshuang, but this time it had become another girl. As for Dai Shuangshuang, she had been at her house accompanying Feng Yue that day.

Yan Lin leaned back slightly in her seat. The car's air conditioning was running efficiently, making her feel much more comfortable.

But her mind always felt shrouded in a layer of fog. There must be something she hadn't noticed.

Soon, their car stopped at the hospital. Mo Yixu had already contacted Wei Yuran from the car, so they could go directly to his office.

After reaching the office, Yan Lin left Mo Yixu outside and went in to see Wei Yuran alone.

Feng Yue sat in the living room, looking at the home that had returned to loneliness, and slowly exhaled.

This was the first time she realized that she too was afraid of solitude.

In the past, no matter how long she waited at home, her love for Yan Lin could overcome all negative emotions.

But now, she suddenly became afraid.

That loneliness, suppressed for too long, was like a roaring tsunami about to engulf her completely.

"Ring—"

The phone placed on the sofa suddenly rang, and it was this ringtone that instantly pulled Feng Yue out of that suffocating sense of loneliness.

She was like a drowning person frantically grasping the last lifeline before her.

Only when she answered the phone did Feng Yue feel as if she had come back to life, while her palms and back were covered with a fine layer of cold sweat.

"Hello." Feng Yue's voice was slightly hoarse.

Dai Shuangshuang's lively and cheerful voice came through the phone: "Sister Yue Yue, would you like to come out for dinner with my sister tonight?"

Feng Yue quietly caught her breath, then calmed herself before saying: "Your sister has something to do and left. If we're having dinner, it might just be you and me."

She knew she couldn't be alone at home right now.

Anyone would do, as long as they could talk with her.

Sure enough, Dai Shuangshuang on the other end, hearing this, complained with obvious displeasure: "She's too busy! She doesn't even have time to have dinner with you!"

Feng Yue gave a bitter smile, thinking to herself that Yan Lin might not even come home for dinner on their wedding anniversary, let alone on such ordinary, mundane days.

"That's fine then. I'll come pick you up later. I saw that a new Cantonese private kitchen¹ opened in the city center—let's try it!"

"Okay."

After hanging up the phone, Feng Yue finally relaxed her tense nerves, though her head was throbbing with a dull ache.

Feng Yue got up and found painkillers from the bag of medicine she had brought back from the hospital, taking one pill according to Professor Fang's instructions.

She planned to take a bath to relax. Being constantly tense like this wasn't a good sign.

In the steamy bathroom, Feng Yue stepped into the bathtub. The warm water wrapped tightly around her body, and the feeling of the hot water soothing her muscles was so comfortable that she let out a sigh of relief.

Steam rose in the bathroom, and gradually Feng Yue's consciousness seemed to drift away in this thick mist.

Somehow, she suddenly remembered that graduation trip.

Hot springs, thick mist, and that kiss that made her tremble with fear just thinking about it.

The ninth-grade graduation trip—Feng Yue and Yan Lin had gone together, along with Yan Lin's childhood friend, Fu Sixue.

After that gala performance when Feng Yue became aware of her feelings for Yan Lin, she began quietly infiltrating Yan Lin's social circle.

Fortunately, Yan Lin wasn't someone who made friends easily. The only person around her who could be considered a friend was her classmate and deskmate, Fu Sixue.

If Feng Yue wanted to pursue Yan Lin, naturally she would start with Fu Sixue. Speaking of which, the way she and Fu Sixue met was quite dramatic.

Fu Sixue was the type of little girl with an angelic face but a devilish mind. Those unfamiliar with her would naturally be deceived by her angelic appearance, and adolescent boys were among them.

At that time, the boys in school were divided into several groups based on their family backgrounds. One boy had fallen for Fu Sixue, and she had rejected him many times.

But he continued to pester her relentlessly, until one day after school, when Fu Sixue was alone preparing to go home, he cornered her in the school's small garden.

Feng Yue happened to pass by and helped Fu Sixue by calling the patrolling duty teacher.

That's how the two got to know each other, and later the three of them grew closer, even going on their middle school graduation trip together.

It was during this graduation trip that Fu Sixue noticed Feng Yue's feelings.

In the misty hot spring pool, with a girl leaning against the edge with her eyes closed in relaxation, Feng Yue's eyes were almost openly fixed on Yan Lin.

Fu Sixue, who had just changed clothes and entered, saw exactly this scene.

She smiled slightly, and when Feng Yue heard movement and looked toward the entrance, she discovered Fu Sixue's figure.

For a moment, she couldn't tell whether her face was burning from embarrassment or from the hot spring.

Fu Sixue raised her eyebrows and pressed her palm down at her, signaling her not to panic.

Thus, the two girls with different thoughts both understood the meaning in each other's eyes.

However, even when the three began chatting later, Fu Sixue didn't show anything unusual, so Feng Yue finally relaxed a little.

Later, they had soaked in the hot spring long enough and were all getting hungry, so they prepared to leave.

But just as the three were standing up, Feng Yue felt an impact at her lower back. She slipped and lunged forward, and Yan Lin happened to be standing in front of her.

Yan Lin was also caught off guard by Feng Yue's unexpected fall. She lost her footing, and both of them fell to the ground.

At that moment, Feng Yue acutely felt her lips touch something soft and moist.

This sensation was fleeting, but she clearly knew what it was.

Yan Lin had accidentally kissed the corner of her mouth.

This realization instantly ignited Feng Yue's cheeks. Her face, ears, and neck were instantly flooded with a rosy flush.

"Are you okay?"

Yan Lin's voice came from above Feng Yue's head, followed by Fu Sixue's slightly amused concern.

"A-Yue, A-Lin, are you both alright!"

Feng Yue quickly scrambled up from Yan Lin's body, then asked with some concern: "Yan Lin, are you okay? Did you hurt yourself anywhere?"

Before Yan Lin could answer, she quickly apologized: "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, it's all because I didn't stand steady. Let's quickly ask if there's a first aid kit."

Yan Lin sat up and grabbed Feng Yue's arm with one hand, looking at her calmly and saying lightly: "I'm fine, don't be anxious."

Fu Sixue, seeing her two friends like this, knew she had gone too far and quickly coughed to help them both up.

Yan Lin's gaze briefly swept over her, then she took Fu Sixue's offered arm to stand up.

Seeing that Yan Lin really wasn't injured anywhere, Feng Yue finally breathed a sigh of relief, then quietly turned to glare at Fu Sixue.

What happened after that?

Feng Yue lay in the bathtub, the warm yellow light veiled by the bathroom steam. She slightly opened her eyes, recalling that unexpected kiss.

Later, it seemed to just fade away without resolution.

Only she—only she always remembered that fleeting kiss that had fallen on the corner of her mouth.

She later had a private chat with Fu Sixue, who didn't object to her feelings for Yan Lin and even vowed to help.

But shortly after they entered high school, Fu Sixue's family moved abroad due to some circumstances, and they gradually lost contact.

Later, until her own death, she never heard news of Fu Sixue again.

The water in the bathtub had grown somewhat cool. Looking at the gradually dissipating steam, Feng Yue became much clearer-headed.

She couldn't help but reproach herself again—why did she have to think about things related to Yan Lin?

But just then, she heard the sound of a car horn from downstairs. She knew it was Dai Shuangshuang arriving.

She got up from the bathtub, tidied herself up a bit, then changed clothes and went downstairs to go with Dai Shuangshuang to that newly opened private kitchen.

The two quickly arrived at the restaurant. Feng Yue had initially thought that being a new place, not many people would know about it, but when they got there, she discovered this restaurant seemed quite popular.

"Shuangshuang, we didn't make a reservation—should we queue up?" Feng Yue looked at the long line of cars parked outside, her brow slightly furrowed.

Seeing this, Dai Shuangshuang smiled mysteriously, then picked up her bag and opened the car door first: "Sister Yue Yue, don't worry, I've arranged everything!"

Feng Yue smiled and shook her head, then followed her out of the car.

The two had a smooth passage all the way, not like those without reservations. Looking at the restaurant's interior decoration, Feng Yue nodded approvingly—this place really had something special, no wonder so many cars were parked outside.

The two were led by the waitstaff to a private room toward the back.

Only after sitting down did Dai Shuangshuang smile and wink at Feng Yue: "Sister Yue Yue, how is it? This place is nice, isn't it?"

Feng Yue nodded: "Mm, you can tell the decoration and everything was done with care. I wonder how the food tastes."

"You can definitely trust the taste—it's my recommendation, how could it not be delicious!"

"That's true."

The two ordered their food, and then Dai Shuangshuang brought up the main topic.

"Sister Yue Yue, do you remember that video I filmed of you cooking before?"

Feng Yue took a sip of tea and nodded: "I remember. What about it?"

"I tagged your account before, but you don't really post much, so many people came to find me, saying they wanted to see you cook more."

Hearing this, Feng Yue looked up at her with some surprise: "Watch me cook?"

"Mm-hmm. Why don't you cook again sometime? I'll film some more video for you, then edit it to satisfy them." Dai Shuangshuang asked tentatively. She didn't know if this would trouble Feng Yue, so she didn't dare tell the whole truth.

Actually, that video had become more popular than either of them had imagined.

Whether it was Feng Yue's cooking technique, her slender, fair fingers that appeared on screen, or that profile that briefly appeared for just a moment.

All of it had caused quite a discussion online.

Dai Shuangshuang's account already had some followers, and with the video being reposted by several entertainment bloggers², it inexplicably became popular.

Dai Shuangshuang really couldn't handle everyone's crazy tagging and comments anymore, which was why she came to ask Feng Yue.

Feng Yue lowered her head and pondered for a moment, then said: "Since we're filming, let's do it properly. Don't just brush people off. I'm quite surprised that people like watching me cook."

Feng Yue didn't want to brush people off. She had experienced how painful it felt to have one's affection ignored and dismissed.

Although the netizens' fondness for her was different from her own feelings.

Footnotes:

¹ Cantonese private kitchen (粵菜私廚) - An upscale, intimate dining concept where chefs serve traditional Cantonese cuisine in a more personal, home-like setting rather than a large restaurant. These are often exclusive and require reservations.

² Entertainment bloggers (娛樂大V) - Influential social media accounts (particularly on Weibo) that focus on entertainment news and celebrity content. "大V" (da V) refers to verified accounts with large followings.